the IPKF fiasco in Sri Lanka first-hand, India was not willing to risk the lives of its citizens in Afghanistan.

India refused the offer. Giving priority to improving relations with Pakistan, concerned about getting militarily involved in Afghanistan (and not knowing where it would stop), India was wary of sending troops to Afghanistan or routing India's developmental assistance through the US. It was also not keen on being seen as part of an international 'occupying' force. Under strain from communal Hindu-Muslim tensions, siding with the West by sending troops to Afghanistan ran the risk of getting branded that India was participating in the 'killing [of] Muslims all over the world'.[40] Both the NDA and the UPA governments wanted to avoid this. The Gujarat riots in February–March 2002, which witnessed one of the worst carnage of Muslim minorities in the history of independent India, had accentuated the need for India to ensure that it did not make enemies in the Muslim world. Only a strict bilateral and non-military relationship with Afghanistan could ensure such diplomatic balancing. Shyam Saran, who was foreign secretary at the time, dealt with the issue and confirms that India's 'response always used to be that whatever is required by Afghanistan, we will respond to a request from the Afghan government … there was always a very conscious effort on our part to keep a very distinct personality for India dealing with Afghanistan [and] not be seen as part and parcel of an American led effort'.[41] India was anyways highly skeptical of the forty countries doing counter-insurgency and the US focused on Al Qaeda.[42]

Indian and US political cycles were not conducive for a meaningful strategic partnership in Afghanistan either. As Shashank, India's foreign secretary (2003–04), says, not just Washington, 'most NATO countries said that we don't want India anywhere, because Pakistan is our best bet. Pakistan does not want India, so we also don't want India. Only Germans said, all right, in our area of responsibility, we don't mind Indians coming and helping. And these were all civilian projects, these had nothing to do with defence, law, and order'.[43] When the US shifted its focus to Iraq in 2003 and required more international assistance in Afghanistan (including by regional allies such as India), India was not keen. Pakistan's unreliability in the Afghan war had become apparent by then. In a secret cable sent to Washington in 2005 by the then US ambassador to